with its long-term financial architecture. The government also enacted the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Bill that overhauled decades-old nuclear laws. It ended state monopoly in the nuclear power sector by allowing full private sector participation and sorted out civil liability issues that had dissuaded foreign investors from coming in.

On the welfare front, the Modi government boldly rebranded the Manmohan-era Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MNREGA) as VB-G-RAM G (Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin). Showcasing it as NDA's all-new employment scheme, it increased the guarantee of work from 100 to 125 days, but raised the contribution of states from the earlier 10 per cent to 40 per cent. The Opposition saw in the acronym an explicit attempt by the Modi government to recast welfare as part of its larger Hindutva politics and criticised it for increasing the burden on states. In its defence, the government pointed out that the scheme was two decades old and needed a revamp to ensure greater accountability, plug leakages and create meaningful assets.

By the end of year, it was clear that Modi would not allow political compulsions to come in the way of economic ambitions. As Dr Pramod Mishra, principal secretary to the prime minister, elaborates, "These are landmark reforms that need political will and carry risks, but the prime minister is prepared to do them because they are necessary for growth. It is full speed ahead for the Reform Express that the PM mentions." What about the fresh focus on boosting demand through various measures? Mishra is clear: "It's not about either supply or demand. We continue to back the supply side with measures such as infrastructure spending and performance-linked incentives while also taking measures to boost demand and these have already shown

"Though they needed political will and carried risks, PM Modi was prepared to carry out these landmark reforms because they are necessary for growth"

— Pramod Mishra, *Principal Secretary to the PM*

Modi: The Mover

REFORM EXPRESS

- Budget 2025 lifts effective tax-free income to Rs 12.75 lakh, benefiting the salaried middle class
- GST tax slabs are restructured, compliance procedures streamlined
- FDI cap for insurance sector increased to 100 per cent, opening the way for full foreign ownership
- The SHANTI Bill, 2025 opens up the atomic energy sector to private and foreign participation

THE WARRIOR

- India's retaliation to the Pahalgam attack, Operation Sindoor, draws a new red line, with PM Modi saying: "If there is a terrorist attack on India, a fitting reply will be given"

CAPTAIN COOL

- Under pressure from US tariffs, diversifies India's export channels by signing trade agreements with the UK and Oman, finalising free trade agreement with New Zealand
- As ties with US come under strain, PM Modi meets Chinese president Xi Jinping and Russian president Vladimir Putin at the SCO Summit in August, signalling that India had other diplomatic options

POLITICAL STRENGTH

- Though the BJP has to depend on allies after the 2024 LS polls, Modi pursues politically risky reforms, like rebranding the MNREGA rural employment scheme as the VB-G-RAM G scheme
- In 2025, after winning the Bihar assembly polls, the Centre reorganises 29 outdated labour laws into four new uniform codes

